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Building BRICS from below?

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The Sixth Summit of the BRICS Heads of States, in Fortaleza, was accompanied by three others: the Business Meeting of BRICS, the Third Trade Union Summit and NGO movements' 'Dialogues on development: the BRICS from the perspective of peoples'. They are composed of actors from very different fields. They also represent projects that sometimes converge and sometimes are in dispute regarding the development model, sustainability, social participation, equality and democracy, among other topics. These actors seek to be part of either the hegemonic or counterhegemonic discourse, along and beyond the state. However, these 'summits' are far from equal in terms of the ability to influence the way BRICS governments take their projects forward.

The first one took place one day before the meeting of presidents and was attended by approximately 700 businessmen and women.[1] The BRICS Business Meeting is the space where large companies from the five countries gather to attempt further integration of their business. They offered a series of recommendations aimed at the government summit, seeking to place the pro-corporate trade and investment position on the agenda. The following recommendations were made: visa facilitation for businessmen; reduction of non-tariff barriers; elimination of dumping and subsidies; creation of a 'BRICS Business Portal' dedicated to information exchange; support for trade fairs, exhibitions and forums within the BRICS countries; a special section in the website of each country for commercial proposals to bring together potential business partners and joint ventures, among others.[2] Business actors also strongly support the creation of the BRICS New Development Bank, aimed at facilitating trade, business and investment, in addition to the potential increase in transactions in local currency (not the US